

Inferno

Chapter 1: The Ember Gate

The city had long forgotten the meaning of silence. Even in the dead of night, a low hum pulsed beneath the streets, like the breath of something ancient buried far below. Elara stood at the edge of the Ember Gate, her fingers trembling as heat radiated from the iron archway. No one crossed it anymore. Not since the fires began.

They said the gate led nowhere. That it had once opened into a thriving district, now swallowed by flame and shadow. But Elara knew better. She had seen the dreams. Endless corridors of ash. Voices whispering her name.

She stepped forward.

Chapter 2: Ash and Echoes

Inside, the world twisted. Buildings leaned like broken teeth, their windows glowing faintly with embers that never died. The air tasted bitter, thick with memory. Every step stirred the dust, and every grain seemed to carry a voice.

"Elara..."

She turned sharply, but no one was there. Only the echo of her own breath.

Deeper she walked, guided not by sight, but by instinct. Something was calling her.

Chapter 3: The Heart of Flame

At the center of the ruins stood a tower, untouched by decay. Its surface shimmered like molten glass, and within it pulsed a living fire. Elara felt her chest tighten as she approached.

The fire spoke without words. It showed her visions: a world before the burning, a mistake, a ritual gone wrong. And at its center—a figure, cloaked in shadow, watching.

"You opened the gate," the voice finally said.

"No," Elara whispered. "I came to close it."

The fire laughed, a sound like cracking stone.

Chapter 4: Descent

The ground split beneath her feet, and Elara fell into darkness. She landed in a cavern where rivers of flame flowed like water. Shapes moved within them—faces, reaching, screaming.

This was no accident. This was a prison.

And she was not alone.

Chapter 5: The Keeper

A figure emerged from the fire, untouched by its fury. His eyes burned brighter than the flames themselves.

"I am the Keeper," he said. "And you are the key."

Elara shook her head, but deep down she understood. The gate had never been meant to keep something out.

It was meant to keep something in.

Chapter 6: Inferno

The truth shattered her. The city, the fire, the voices—they were all part of her. A power buried, denied, and finally unleashed.

The Keeper stepped closer. "You can end this."

Elara closed her eyes. The flames surged, roaring louder than ever before.

Then, silence.

When she opened them again, the fire was gone.

But so was the world she knew.

And in its place—

Only ash, and the faint glow of something waiting to begin again.